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his advisory role and French President Nicholas Sarkozy may opt out, as could other heads of state.

Reaction in China has been predictable. "The despicable actions of the separatists and those who support their divisive movement tarnish the lofty Olympic spirit," says Jiang Yu, China's foreign ministry spokeswoman. The fact is that despite being so predictable, the Tibet issue and its potential to disrupt the Olympics has caught the Chinese totally off guard. President Hu Jintao only emerged in public to issue a reaction a full fortnight after the trouble in Tibet erupted. Official reaction in Beijing has been clumsy, heavy-



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The protests have embarrassed the Chinese like no other event since the 1989 killings in Tiananmen Square

NEW HERO: Jin Jing protecting the torch from protesters (left)

handed, bureaucratic and deaf to criticism, more reminiscent of the communist regime of old than the modern, open face that the Olympics are meant to portray. In the light of China's growing economic and political clout, it's a face they didn't want the world to see.

Andy Wei, an American citizen who was in Beijing on business, has an explanation. "The Chinese operate under a system of collective decision-making that becomes a hindrance when the state needs to be flexible and nimble-footed," he says. The real problem, as local diplomats point out, is that the top leadership cannot afford to be viewed by the public as being soft and indecisive—punishment for official failure is